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FLESH OF WORDS: CONFRONTATION, NAVIGATION, AND INTEGRITY IN THE ENGLISH CLASSROOM

Abstract

This article offers a quasi-testimonio of my experiences with education and creating an introductory multiethnic literature college course. Engaging Critical Race Theory and Latina Feminisms, specifically scholars such as Kimberlé Crenshaw, Gloria Anzaldúa and Aurora Levins Morales, it argues that curriculum construction is never apolitical and therefore requires a demystification of historical contexts as well as challenges to settler colonial legacies. This article offers a case-study of how I design assignments, select readings, and work with students as they are introduced to different literatures and communities. It also offers models for self-reflection and ways to cultivate classes that engage the written word as holding the flesh of resistance.

Keywords: *Feminist pedagogy, Critical race theory, Latina feminisms, Multiethnic literature, Decolonial education*

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I earned my PhD in Latino Literature from the University of Texas San Antonio. My research focuses on Puerto Rican women's literature and representations of subversive empowerment that occurs in creative writing. My teaching principles are guided not only by my understanding of the literature we explore but also the integrity of the discipline in which I work.

The drive behind my professional work is as much intertwined with my personal life as not. Kimberlé Crenshaw has previously articulated the importance of understanding intersectionality and ways that power and privilege impact different aspects of identity. I am mixed—British and Puerto Rican—a woman, heterosexual, and from a low socio-economic background.

My subject position informs how people respond to me when I enter a room, and also informs how I know to react to that room. [1] My education has provided me frameworks that help me to better grapple with these realities. It is not that I was unaware of my life circumstances when I arrived at college, but my academic career has taught me to have a greater consciousness about the world in which I live and been an integral part of my coming to consciousness. It also influences how I interact with students and colleagues.

My professional life—my research, teaching, and creative interests—is grounded in Latina Feminisms. Gloria Anzaldúa and Cherríe Moraga's "theory in the flesh,"[2] first described in This Bridge Called My Back, details how the daily, lived experiences of women of color show the ways that power functions in a structure and also how women of color navigate these structures. It provides an invaluable framework that highlights how these navigations indicate highly attuned acumen for surviving oppression as well as subversive acts for thriving beyond its limitations. In grounding my work with this understanding, I must always come back to the real, tangible experiences of macro-level power and its manifestations in the micro-level.

The best way, then, to properly introduce myself and my work is to share my own experiences, to create a quasi-testimonio that draws from the insights provided by such texts as The Latina Feminist Group's Telling to Live.[3] To share my pedagogical and scholarly choices, I must explain my educational pathway and how I have arrived where I am at now. I attended a small liberal arts college in upstate New York, and honestly it was by accident. I had arrived from abroad during my junior year of high school and had no real conception of New York as more than New York City and some small towns around it. But the campus Financial Aid Department had a team that recognized how hard I worked and how hard I would fight to earn my degree. The package I received made it possible for me to attend their school. I will forever be grateful for the many hours they worked to support me getting to graduation.

During my undergraduate degree, I remember a faculty line being added on campus—one in Latin American History, and though he might have already been there I also became aware of

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[1] There are other aspects of my subject position that could be mentioned, that continue to indicate different ways that I access am unable to access power and privilege. However, out of respect for my own privacy, I have chosen to leave some out.

[2] Gloria Anzaldúa and Cherríe Moraga, eds., This Bridge Called My Back, 4th ed. (SUNY University Press, 2015).

[3] Latina Feminist Group, Telling to Live (Duke University Press, 2001).

a faculty member in Latino Politics—and that was about it. As much as I wanted to study writings by Latino authors, there was not a specialist in my major. While some of my English courses would occasionally include a Latino author, there was no dedicated class to either Puerto Rican literature specifically, or Latino literature more broadly. Sometimes I would spend hours sitting on the floors between library shelves or at the local used bookstore scouring for Latino authors—just to find someone. Towards the end of my degree, though, the department did offer courses on colonialism and postcolonial literature, and it was through those classes and with the help of faculty in those areas that I was able to ground my early understandings of how colonial discourse and white supremacy exist within literature. This work, in combination with courses in Gender and Women's Studies, gave me language to help formulate ideas about where I wanted to go even as I was figuring out what it meant to get there.

I applied for graduate school and was first accepted into a great New England campus where I would get to study under a foremost Puerto Rican poet. To say I was thrilled does not cover it. To have a chance to learn from him and grow was everything to me. My arrival, though, was not as exciting. Although accepted, I did not receive a fellowship and there was no formalized specialty track in Latino literature. The director of the program stated to me, and it will stay with me forever, "Why would I give a fellowship to you when I could give it to someone else." My entire life I had worked hard—multiple jobs through undergraduate, striving for a strong GPA to earn scholarships to pay for what I could not cover with grants and loans—and to hear his words and sit in that office and have to take it? I never felt more like someone had put a mirror up in front of me to tell me how much I did not belong.[4] I cannot say if the scars from such moments ever go away. But I can say that they don't define my limits.

Perhaps my own stubbornness, or maybe my refusal to be reduced to the inferred label "unworthy" by someone who did not know me, led me to apply to other programs as a transfer. Maybe I was already birthing my own "chingonaness" as Alma Zaragoza-Petty[5] describes it. But, after all, I was in a program that would not support me. It also was a program that, although I would get to work with a handful of people who could guide me, would ultimately have me studying Latino literature as a side project, earning a "certificate" in Latin American Studies while otherwise focusing on what—to me—appeared to be a curriculum strong in Anglo-US and British writers. I decided that fighting for myself meant finding a space where I could grow. I applied to several PhD programs and earned offers to join their campuses. I ultimately chose to attend UTSA because not only would I be supported but I would get to study Latino Literature as Latino Literature. No side project. No scrambling to cobble together classes from across the campus to make up some sort of educational pathway.

The scholars with whom I studied over the next five years provided me with experiences and opportunities for knowledge acquisition that, quite frankly, I cannot imagine having anywhere else. It means something to have artistic creations from your community represented; for that representation to be from the inside, rather than presented as an artifact looked at from the outside like a guinea pig that managed to wake up one day and articulate a manifesto in a human language. It means something to have that representation not to be exceptional, or the exception, but just the way things are.

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[4] Rukiya King, "Microaggressions, Imposter Phenomenon, and People of Color: A Quantitative Analysis" (PhD diss., City University of New York, 2022).

[5] Alma Zaragoza-Petty, Chingona: Owning Your Inner Badass for Healing and Justice (Broadleaf Books, 2022).

From Texas I moved to Louisiana and taught at an arts high school in New Orleans. An emerging program, I was one of a handful of faculty members hired to create an English curriculum designed to collaborate with History/Social Studies. Here, I continued to grow but in a different way. Gloria Anzaldúa[6] describes facultad as a kind of multi-awareness that allows people to "see" beneath the surface of social situations. It means that, when we engage with our facultad, we perceive the narratives we are told or the manifestation of social circumstances, and also perceive that there is more occurring, more that needs to be understood. It is the tingly sensation that turns on our lightbulbs that something is off. In New Orleans, my facultad as an educator strengthened. I remember the oddness of teaching about the US invasion of Mexico and takeover of Puerto Rico while being the only Latina academic faculty member. Teaching about the thirteenth amendment to a group of students who did not have a black faculty member in their high school academics. And then working with another group of students who had watched as their black academic teachers seemed to disappear. It raised some very real, very important questions for me: How do you normalize talking about literature and art from a community when you are alone, or there are no educators from that community present? How do you teach students to see the art from within the community lens in which it was created when there is no one present who has that lens?

I moved to central New York in 2015 to take on a tenure track position in English. My official work was to teach Latino Literature and Culture. I was the only faculty member on campus based in Latino Studies although there were several in Latin American Studies. I spent the next several years building a curriculum in this literary field for my department and finding people across the campus with whom to create a Latino and Latin American Studies program. In so many ways, I felt and feel the support of the people in my department and many people from across the school. But, on campus, I had and have no senior Latina faculty to model my career off of or seek guidance from. I am currently one of a small handful senior full time Latina faculty members. By this I mean single digits. It has been incredibly hard: I must go not only outside of the campus but often outside of the region when I want to talk to colleagues about my work or the designing of classes. It can be incredibly lonely. As time has progressed, I have had the opportunity to see Latina and Latino faculty members be hired into tenure track positions, and it has been with great joy that I have been able to cheer them on and support them in whatever ways I can. There is hope for the future.

My research draws from an understanding that while we must account for how power works we also must refuse to only be a sum of oppression. When possible, I draw from Aurora Levins Morales's Medicine Stories,[7] and especially her exploration of cultural activism. I am interested in how artists can heal wounds wrought by colonial structures, and also how what Miguel Algarín and Miguel Piñero describe as "dusmic poetics" enables Puerto Rican authors to "fight with words."[8] I have sought to explore how Puerto Rican women, especially, claim their flesh in their writings as a decolonial act of empowerment.[9] Core to this work, though, is a belief that literature by Latinos needs to be read, appreciated, and understood on its own merits, rather than sashayed into default supremacist norms or beliefs. At times I think I might be

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[6] Gloria Anzaldúa, *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza*, 3rd ed. (Aunt Lute, 2007), 60.

[7] Aurora Levins Morales, *Medicine Stories: History, Culture and the Politics of Integrity* (South End Press, 1998).

[8] Miguel Algarín and Miguel Piñero, *Nuyorican Poetry: An Anthology of Puerto Rican Words and Feelings* (William Morrow, 1975), 127.

[9] Roberta Hurtado, *Decolonial Puerto Rican Women's Writings: Subversion in the Flesh* (Springer, 2019).

successful, but I also know I need to keep pushing forward, challenging my own assumptions and also holding myself accountable to learning.

I was once asked to define my values as an academic and a leader. The first thing that came to mind was that I believe in education as a process; I believe in the process of learning—not as an end goal or dead thing that gets "accomplished" but as a lifelong dedication and pursuit. Learning is not easy. Core to learning is the ability to attain knowledge, and by that I mean openness to think, to gain, to engage critically. Integral to this ability is what Anzaldúa describes as the path to conocimiento.[10] A seven-stage pathway, the path to concomiento contains within it awareness of the fact that being confronted with knowledge that we had previously been aware of can be hard: it can be earth-shattering. As such, it is important to move through the reality of gaining knowledge as having within it tensions and spaces of growth, contradictions, seemingly at-odds shifts in sensibility, and ultimately an awareness that for every time we come to consciousness about something we are able to move to a greater level of complexity of engagement but we are never finished in the path.

An example of how I engage this awareness when teaching is a course I have regularly had in rotation since 2015, a course that many campuses have as an introduction to Multiethnic US Literature course. It is often an early division course (for freshman and sophomores) and in many cases fulfills some sort of general education requirement.

I taught this class each year while on tenure track, and almost every year since earning tenure although it has recently left my rotation. At my current campus, this course is a requirement for students enrolled in an early-education major. My understanding is that this requirement is to ensure that future educators will have read writings by authors from a variety of US communities and, as such, be able to draw from that experience while making their own pedagogical choices and/or teaching students from different cultures.

In my experience, many of the students enrolled in this course share similarities in terms of being from the same region of New York, of Anglo-US and middle-class backgrounds, and gender. Most students want to do well in the class. They want to pass the class, finish school, and become teachers. They are often genuinely nice students. Most have only read one or two books by an author of color, and for many it is the first time that they are in a class taught by someone of Puerto Rican heritage. For most of these students, it is the first class where they have read exclusively non-hegemonic writers rather than exclusively Anglo-US/Western European writers.

These facts, together, in many ways reflect practices of settler colonialism that obfuscate how it works even as it is actively working.[11] To have spent the majority of their educational experiences having specific communities presented both in their books and as authors of their books means these students often have a lack of familiarity with either literary texts or interpretations from beyond those communities.[12] Practices of inclusion and exclusion carry a very real lesson for students. For, at the same time that the practice of normalizing through presentation occurs there is a simultaneous method of erasure of others in motion.[13] Some

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[10] Gloria Anzaldúa, "Now Let Us Shift…The Path of Conocimiento…Inner Works, Public Acts," in *This Bridge We Call Home*, ed. Gloria Anzaldúa and AnaLouise Keating (Routledge, 2002), 540–78.

[11] Alma Zaragoza-Petty, *Chingona: Owning Your Inner Badass for Healing and Justice* (Broadleaf Books, 2022), 178.

[12] LaGarrett King, "Foreword," in *Doing Race in Social Studies: Critical Perspectives*, ed. Prentice Chander (Information Age Publishing, 2015), x.

[13] King, "Foreword," x; Barrette Holmes Pitner, The Crime Without a Name: Ethnocide and the Erasure of Culture in America (Counterpoint, 2021), 5.

pundits would have it that not engaging this practice of inclusion/erasure is a form of indoctrination.[14] With no irony intended, the argument appears to be that challenging practices of cultural genocide in curriculum construction is a form of moral and intellectual corruption. In many ways, this belief seems an organic outgrowth of debates regarding definitions of cultural genocide, and methods of inclusion and need for compatibility with "public order" that occurred during the drafting of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.[15] Thus, my class can be very jarring for students raised in an education system born from this lineage. Students are being confronted with not just new literature but also an awareness that there are alternative epistemologies that do not center Anglo-US/Western European ways of knowing and communicating; and that they have been intentionally not taught these.

The success of this intentional erasure includes the creation of gaps in terms of what students have been taught about what "race" means and how to talk about it. Many of the Anglo-US students I have taught know that they are not supposed to say certain words because those words are racist. Similar to findings identified by Linda Tropp and Christina Rucinksi[16] regarding K-12 educators attempting to engage in "race talk," students often admit that they fear saying something that could be construed as racist. So, many default to saying that they do not see race or that race does not influence how they perceive other people,[17] or looking down when asked to speak about why an author would make a depiction a certain way. Engaging Anzaldúa helps me to remain present and aware of why students have these reactions: No one wants to be called "racist" because they have been brought up to believe that "racists" are really from the South (something explained to me my first semester on campus), and being called "racist" means there is something inherently wrong with them (and thus, to be Southern is bad even as the stars and bars fly outside homes throughout the region). Class discussion stalls and then dies when people are afraid to learn because learning requires honesty and honesty makes for vulnerability and vulnerability is scary.

I try to begin the semester—not from a deficit—but from a consideration of why it is important to read writings by authors of color from within the frameworks of their communities. Artists such as Zora Neale Hurston have pointed to this reality, noting, for instance, that it is possible to know black lives as more than defensive posturing or reactions to the actions of white people.[18] For students who have never been asked to consider this fact in a real, tangible way, we must go slow so that they can process what they are learning. For students who have had such an opportunity in the past, this pace allows for more room to engage self-reflection.

With this lesson in mind, I have the class start the semester by first reading excerpts from Audre Lorde's (1984) Sister Outsider and Martín Espada's (1998) Zapata's Disciples. [19] From Lorde, we consider "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House" (1984) and "Poetry is Not a Luxury" (1984), and Espada "Poetry Like Bread" (1998). These selections help

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[14] Kali Jerrard, "Literature, Indoctrination, and DEI, Oh My," National Association of Scholars, March 14, 2023, https://www.nas.org/blogs/article/literature-indoctrination-and-dei-oh-my.

[15] Johannes Morsink, "Cultural Genocide, the Universal Declaration, and Minority Rights," Human Rights Quarterly 21, no. 4 (1999): 1016, https://doi.org/10.1353/hrq.1999.0052.

[16] Linda Tropp and Christina Rucinski, "How Implicit Racial Bias and Concern about Appearing Racist Shape K–12 Teachers' Race Talk with Students," Social Psychology of Education 24 (2022): 697–717, https://doi.org/10.1007/s11218-022-09715-5.

[17] Meghan Burke, *Colorblind Racism* (Polity Press, 2019).

[18] Henry Louis Gates, Jr., "Afterword," in *Their Eyes Were Watching God*, by Zora Neale Hurston (HarperCollins, 1990), 199.

[19] Audre Lorde, Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches by Audre Lorde (Crossing Press, 1984); Martín Espada, *Zapata's Disciple* (South End Press, 1998).

situate students into a space in which we focus on the importance of close reading and consider how each author attends to our current moment as existing in the avalanches of history while simultaneously not chaining themselves to the idea of only ever being a sum of oppressive historical moments. Occasionally, I teach Peggy MacIntosh's "White Privilege: Unpacking the Invisible Knapsack"[20] to help students identify how "privilege" is not about being able to buy expensive things but instead about the things that individuals do not have to think about or worry about in their daily lives.

As we move through these different writings, I remind students that there will be moments when they feel discomfort with what they read or even moments when they reject what the authors are sharing. I ask them to mark where those moments of discomfort/rejection happen, and to sit with the feeling and write down why they are having that reaction. I discuss with them why this step is important, and that it is necessary even if doing it means they cannot complete the full reading assignment. Not all students take up this task, but the ones who do often come in with points about what they understand as interpretations that they think are unfair, and even historical information that they are unsure about. In these moments of sharing, we gain an opportunity to discuss the importance of intersectionality [21] and to discuss what they know or have studied about the author at hand and their communities. In many cases, what emerges in such moments is awareness of what students have been taught to not think about, or think critically about.[22]

From there, we move on to read formulations of "race" that emerged in the Enlightenment era from philosophers such as Immanuel Kant and Thomas Jefferson. An invaluable text in this section is Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze's Race and the Enlightenment: A Reader, which offers a selection of such writings.[23] I have a worksheet that accompanies the readings that provides students a way to manage writings that are stylistically unfamiliar to them and also identify pertinent points they might otherwise miss. Once they work through these sheets in small groups, we map out the information and consider if we know of any contemporary examples where speculations these writers put forward manifest in our current moment. We have actively connected, for instance, Georges Cuvier (1805/1997), his dissection of Sara Baartman's anatomy, and depictions of "the venus hottentot" against more contemporary images such as the 2014 cover image of Kim Kardashian on Paper magazine.[24] Within these moments, students are given an opportunity to situate what they have been trained—in often unconscious ways—to ignore and simultaneously accept how race is understood in our era and how they are part of the discussion. This opportunity also adjusts the discussion so that the class eases away from fears of "accusations" of being racist and instead to understanding that we act in a context, and while it is important to contextualize words and behavior we must also then take on the responsibility of compassionate accountability. [25]

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[20] Peggy MacIntosh, "White Privilege: Unpacking the Invisible Knapsack," *Peace and Freedom Magazine* (July/August 1989): 10–12.

[21] Kimberlé Crenshaw, "Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity Politics, and Violence Against Women of Color," *Stanford Law Review* 43, no. 6 (1991): 1241–99, https://doi.org/10.2307/1229039.

[22] Burke, *Colorblind Racism.*

[23] Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze, *Race and the Enlightenment: A Reader* (Wiley-Blackwell, 1997).

[24] Justin Parkinson, "The Significance of Sarah Baartman," BBC News, January 7, 2016, https://www.bbc.com/news/magazine-35240987.

[25] Ami Kantawala, "Abolitionist Teaching: Building a Future of Accountability, Grace, and Compassion," *Art Education* 76, no. 1 (2023): 8–13, https://doi.org/10.1080/00043125.2022.2155000; Roberta Hurtado, "Intimate Retrofits," in Not Token Gestures, ed. Roberta Hurtado (Lexington Books, forthcoming).

As the course continues, we read through poetry and novels from authors coming from a wide range of backgrounds and experiences. Students complete daily writing assignments that allow them to frame their thoughts while also staying grounded within the texts. For instance, one question might ask students to consider a quote and explain why an author uses a specific word, and how that word connects to other areas of the reading they did that day. Students are thereby given a specific area of the text to look for, but also a chance to expand what they think and have ownership over how they choose to respond and connect. My job is not to tell them if they are "right" or "wrong," but instead to ask them to consider what the author is presenting to them and how they make sense of that information. In another assignment, I ask students to work in small groups to research the author's background and give the class historical information and events about their communities. In this way, class members have the chance to place these texts in a longer history, showing geo-social connections. It also empowers students to find information about why an author might represent a particular aspect of a neighborhood, or why they pay attention to the ways that historical events impact them in the present moment.

I am perfectly imperfect. I have seen this phrase emerging more and more recently, and every time I see it the authors are not using it to explain away their mistakes or excuse themselves for bad behavior. Instead, the usage often seems to reflect the fact that they are aware of themselves as always in a space of transition, always on a path of learning and growing.[26] As an educator, I know that this is true of students, of colleagues, and of myself. I cannot ask students to be willing to be open to learning if I am not equally responsible to keep myself open. Yet, as an educator, my responsibilities also include ensuring that I am working with students to attain quality standards that align with higher education. This task might seem contradictory. In many ways, it is. Many of these "standards" are part of the educational practices that come from a legacy of colonialism. But just as true is that this contradiction requires that I think through the connection between what I teach, how I teach, and my own understanding of "academic excellence." It is a balancing act between expectations, standards, and genuineness.

Sometimes, I feel like a failure. Standing in front of a seemingly insurmountable wall, I wonder if anything I do makes any sort of difference. Is there any point to me pushing for students to read works by writers of color? Are we just condemned to walk in circles, something akin to the Family Guy episode when Cleveland shares a boardgame about Civil Rights and he notes that no one ever wins the game but instead only hopes to do a little better each time around the board?[27] In these moments, when I can give in to despair,[28] I wonder if it is worth keeping trying or if I should just give up. Should I accept defeat, and give myself over to the lessons of colonialism and begin to work on its behalf? I can easily pick myself apart, tell myself that I am not good enough, or that what I do is not "worth" doing.

Something in my soul revolts. Even in moments of despair, I just…can't. I have to confront these messages for what they are: lessons of colonial oppression. Holding on to my belief in learning allows me to challenge the feeling of failing. It provides me space to self-reflect on what I do, moments where I struggle, moments where I can improve on my work or unknowingly give in to the lessons I have been taught. Simultaneously, to reflect on what I do

[26] Zaragoza-Petty, *Chingona.*

[27] Seth Kearsley, dir., *Family Guy*, season 4, episode 6, "Petarded," aired June 19, 2005, on Fox.

[28] Anzaldúa, "Now Let Us Shift…The Path of Conocimiento…," 550.

right, what I can draw from these experiences to build upon to create a supportive environment conducive to learning.

Part of the process is being aware of what my colleagues expect of me as a literature professor, what students expect of me as a literature professor, and my own response to these. Perhaps akin to the double consciousness described by W.E.B. Du Bois[29] in 1903, for me part of it is also the fact that I cannot only include one epistemological framework as the standard of quality if I am going to strive towards academic excellence. Indeed, "academic excellence" means being able to identify what I do not know and find rigorous information that helps me to understand it; that I am able to put my own ego to the side to consider a variety of lenses; that I can take up different perspectives and ways of knowing as legitimate and, rather than "exceptions," necessarily included in the conversation.

I have to be humble enough to self-reflect when teaching. To accept when I make mistakes and show students the importance of owning our mistakes by doing so in front of them, to acknowledge when I am being confronted by racism, sexism, and other forms of bias from students and peers so that I can better understand how I am being perceived and how to maneuver around it while also not succumbing to it. When I feel myself losing hope, I turn back to Anzaldúa, to Levins Morales, to the Nuyorican poets, and Chicana feminists and so many others who offer their words of flesh as a form of resistance to dehumanizing processes. And with their words in my hands, I push forward.

[29] W. E. B. Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (Signet, 1995), 45.